

THE FLY

Musca



SIZE RANKING 77

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 2.7

GENITIVE Muscae

ABBREVIATION Mus

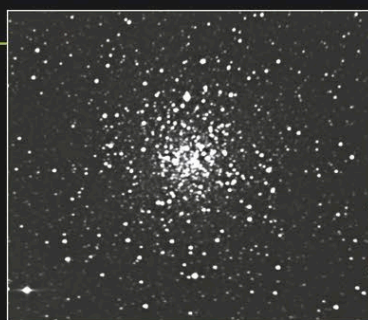
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
April–MayFULLY VISIBLE
14°N–90°S

This modest constellation is to be found in the Milky Way south of Crux and Centaurus. In fact, the southern tip of the dark Coalsack Nebula extends into it from Crux.

Musca is one of the southern constellations introduced at the end of the 16th century by the Dutch navigator-astronomers Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman. It represents a fly.

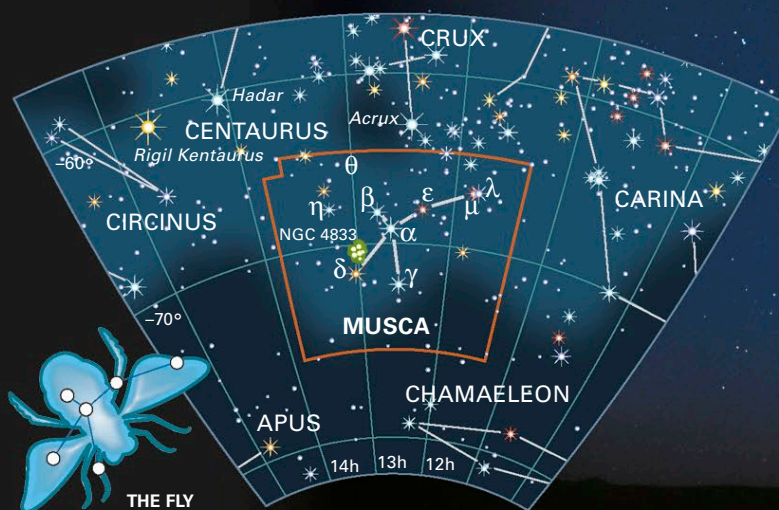
SPECIFIC FEATURES

Theta (θ) Muscae is a double star with components of 6th and 8th magnitude, divisible through a small telescope. The fainter component is an example of a Wolf-Rayet star—a hot star that has lost its outer layers. Musca also has a globular cluster, known as NGC 4833 (see p.295).



NGC 4833

This globular cluster is just visible through binoculars. Individual stars can be resolved with a telescope of 4 in (100 mm) aperture.



FINDING THE FLY

The long axis of the Southern Cross points to Musca, the fly, which lies on the edge of the Milky Way within the southern celestial hemisphere.

THE COMPASSES

Circinus



SIZE RANKING 85

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 3.2

GENITIVE Circini

ABBREVIATION Cir

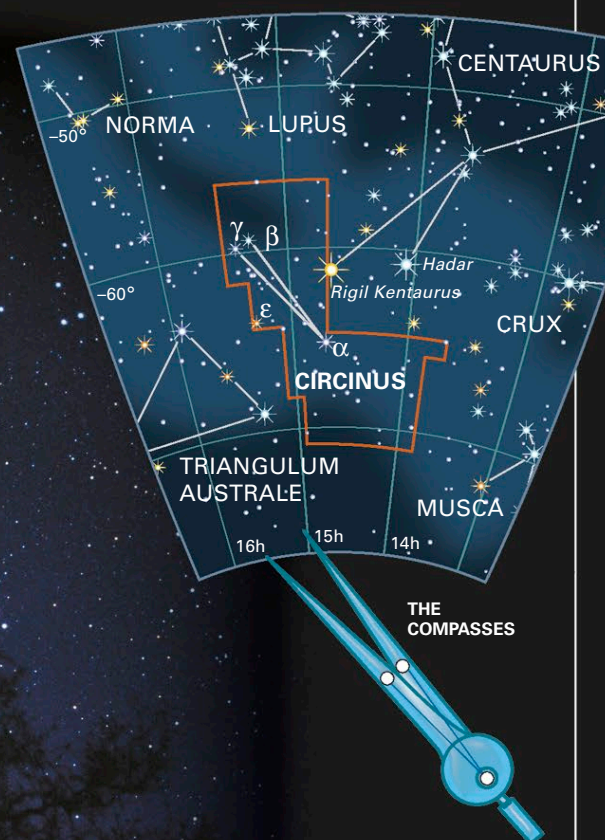
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
May–JuneFULLY VISIBLE
19°N–90°S

Circinus represents a pair of dividing compasses, as used by surveyors and navigators. It is one of the figures introduced in the 18th century by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422).

This small southern constellation is squeezed awkwardly in between Centaurus and Triangulum Australe. It lies next to Alpha (α) Centauri, so it is not difficult to locate.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Circinus contains little of interest for amateur astronomers. Alpha (α) Circini, however, is its one star of note. It is situated against the background of the Milky Way and is easy to identify, being a double with components of 3rd and 9th magnitudes. These are divisible through a small telescope.



GEOMETRIC SHAPE

Circinus forms a slim triangle of stars and is squashed into a sliver of the southern sky next to the brilliant Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Centauri.